



Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Violette Nozière

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Director: Claude Chabrol

Production Companies: Filmel, France 3,
Cinévidéo Inc (Montreal)

Executive Producer: Roger Morand

Producer (Filmel): Eugène Lepicier

Producer (Cinévidéo): Denis Héroux

Production Manager: Francis Peltier

Production Supervisors: Alain Fleury, Bernard Morel

Production Co-ordinator: Claude Léger

Location Manager: Roger Plaisance

Researcher: Jean-Marie Fitère

Assistant Directors: Philippe Delarbre,

Brice Defer-Auboyneau

Screenplay: Odile Barski, Hervé Bromberger,
Frédéric Grendel

Adaptation: Odile Barski

Original book: Jean-Marie Fitère

Director of Photography: Jean Rabier

Editor: Yves Langlois

Production Designer: Jacques Brizzio

Set Decorator: Robert Christidès

Costumes: Pierre Nourry

Make-up: Aïda Carange

Music: Pierre Jansen

Sound Recording: Patrick Rousseau

Sound Re-recording: Alex Pront

Sound Editor: Anne Lafarge

English subtitles: Frances Head, Cinétitres

Cast:

Isabelle Huppert (*Violette Nozière*)

Jean Carmet (*Baptiste Nozière*)

Stéphane Audran (*Germaine Nozière*)

Mario David (*prison director*)

Bernadette Lafont (*Violette's cellmate*)

Lisa Langlois (*Maddy*)

Jean-François Garreud (*Jean Dabin*)

Philippe Procot (*Vésine-Larue*)

Bernard Alane (*young Pinguet*)

Jacqueline Alexandre, Francine Cornu,

Jacqueline Pierreux (*housewives*)

Jean-Marie Arnoux, Gilbert Servien,

Francis Terzian, Roland Travers (*inspectors*)

Albert Augier (*magistrate*)

Serge Bento (*hospital director*)

Serge Berry, Henri Attal (*bystanders*)

Suzanne Berthois (*prison guard*)

Micheline Bourday (*Mme. Oinguet*)

Zoé Chauveau (*Zoé*)

Jean-Pierre Coffe (*Dr Déron*)

Brigitte Défrance (*conciierge at Serry Premises*)

Dora Doll (*Mme. Mayeul*)

Jean-François Dupas

(*inspector at Champs-de-Mars*)

Michel Duplaix (*intern*)

François-Eric Gendron (*1st student*)

Grégory Germain (*Black musician*)

Florence Guerfy (*2nd nurse*)

Raoul Guylad (*old man*)

Henri-Jacques Huet (*Commissioner Guillaume*)

Bernard Lajarrige (*M. de Pinguet*)

Marius Laurey (*neighbour*)

Rudy Lenoir (*onlooker*)

Fabrice Luchini (*Camus*)

Sylvie Moreau (*prison spy*)

François Maistre (*M. Mayeul*)

Jean-Claude Monteils (*man at Vincennes*)

Francine Olivier (*maid*)

Bernard Papineau (*2nd onlooker*)

Jean Parédès (*singer*)

Bruno Rozenker (*ascetic*)

Priscilla Saillard (*Violette as a child*)

Emmanuele Stochl (*young girl*)

'I fell in love with Violette Nozière' by Claude Chabrol

One night in 1933, a girl of 18 began a long odyssey through the Bois de Vincennes in a bus. This was Violette Nozière. Until this night she had lived in her parents' tiny flat with Baptiste, her father, an engine-driver with the railways, and Germaine, her mother, a housewife. A thorough-going pair of inhibited petits bourgeois, the parents kept on day in and day out about their disappointments and about the hopes they entertained for their child. But Violette didn't give a damn about all that: she wanted love, the grand passion, and she wanted lavish spending, gorgeous clothes, a life of bars, dance halls, sports cars, joyrides to the seaside. Her quest was for the ultimate.

But the ultimate was a little seedy-looking: a hotel in the Latin Quarter which she rented by the day with money stolen from her parents so as to be able to receive her friends, students more or less, who all more or less despised her. In the evenings, putting aside her black slashed dress and satin slippers, Violette returned in white ankle socks and pleated skirt to the family hearth where the little girl which she still and always remained in the wilfully blind eyes of her parents was awaited and expected to play pinochle. Violette could tell them nothing; they wouldn't have understood, they would have killed her. So she played a double game: pathetic *femme fatale* by day, reluctant child at night, unhappy child-woman night and day.

Unhappy because of her abortive dreams, unhappy because of this family which, turning morality to convention and hypocrisy to perversion, understood nothing. Perversity of a mother, herself an assurance of femininity, in repressing her daughter on principle as much as from any fear of possible competition; perversity of a father, holding Violette prisoner of his eyes and his insinuations.

Frédérique Tirmont (*1st nurse*)
Didier Valmont (*Serry*)
Maurice Vaudaux (*Willy*)
Dominique Zardi (*waiter*)
Guy Hoffman (*judge*)
Jean Dalmain (*Emile*)
Carine François (*2nd young girl*)
Benoît Ferreux (*boxer*)
Odile Barski (*gypsy*)
Marco Pauly (*barman*)
Louise Chevalier (*old woman*)
Jean Depusse (*assistant commissioner*)
Jeanne Herviale (*grandmother*)
Jean Cherlian (*station boss*)
Jacqueline Jako-Mica (*conciierge at the Nozière's*)
France-Canada 1978
125 mins
Digital

The screening on Sun 20 Sep will be introduced by academic Catherine Dousteysier-Khoze

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Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

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once as proof of her love. That day her parents had treated her abominably,
searching through her things and forcing her to write a humiliating letter to the
man she loved.

That evening, Violette poisoned her parents. Baptiste died. Germaine threw
away half of her dose. She was to survive.

In the middle of the night, Violette returned home. The bodies of her parents
were cluttering up the floor of the tiny apartment. She arranged things to look
like a suicide by gas, and went to alert the neighbours. The Nozière case had
begun.

Wandering around Paris, Violette gave the police the slip. She was no longer
thinking of Dabin. It looks rather as though this crime had made her realise that
her love was not returned – and perhaps realise, too, the futility of her act.
Violette knew she was going to be arrested, that she had accomplished
nothing, that no one had ever understood her, and that her only refuge now lay
in prison. In the end she let the police catch up with her. She proceeded to
confess. Yes, she meant to poison her father but not her mother, never.

She hated her father because he had raped her when she was 13 years old
and continued to enjoy unnatural relations. Her testimony was recorded. She
was confronted with her mother, who abused her and instigated a civil action
against her.

Through this year of 1934, the year of the judicial enquiry and trial, Violette was
alone in her prison, remembering. Yet the affair stirred up a great deal of
interest. Among the champions of family life who were disposed to lynch her,
among the majority who condemned her, and the handful of poets for whom
she symbolised the courage to shatter (in Paul Eluard's words) 'the terrible
serpents' nest of blood relations,' Violette rekindled an old story which
transcended the one of which she was both author and victim, and which only
time could efface from memory.

And it was in fact this road to oblivion that Violette was to take after her
conviction; a road which was to make of her another woman who was finally
pardoned.

The story as I tell it in the film stops with the end of the trial. Its theme is the
mental confusion of an adolescent torn between the rigours of an outmoded
education and the chaos of a reality where questions have no answers.
Violette's crime is the result of this tension between two poles.

Violette herself is a perfect illustration of the natural ambivalence of the human
creature, which can flourish only in an environment that does not stifle it.

I fell in love with Violette Nozière long before I understood her. Others had fallen
under the spell before me: Eluard, Aragon, Magritte, Simone de Beauvoir,
Pierre Brasseur. In trying to bring her to life again, I felt the fascination of her
ambiguities: murderer and saint, liar and true heart, childish yet inspired. I had
to explore her mind, lay bare her dreams, suffer her daily existence. In this
evocation of a headline sensation and a trial which had all France agog while
Hitler was taking over control of Germany, it is no longer a question of judging,
but of understanding.

Monthly Film Bulletin, April 1979 (This article appeared in a press brochure at the 1978 Cannes
Film Festival; translation by Tom Milne)